CURIOUS SPAROOWS · ENCYCLOPEDIC INDEX

SPORTS AND GAMES

Why humans invent games with rules that don't matter, and then care so much

Outdoor and indoor sports · mind games · video games and esports · folk games of India and the world · parasports · history · events · awards · legends · science · ideas · practical guide

Parts	Sections	Sub-sections	Entries	Register rows
18	46	48	272	95

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How to Use This Booklet

This booklet is a map of the world's sports and games: outdoor and indoor sports, mind games, video games and esports, traditional games of India and the world, parasports, history, events, awards, legends, science, ideas and a practical guide. Every entry tells you, in one or two lines, what the thing is and why it matters.

Every entry has an ID (such as SPT-03.1 for cricket). The same ID is the entry's address on curioussparoows.com, where each one is growing into its own page.

How this booklet is organised

Parts: the intro questions, the master map, outdoor and indoor sports, mind games, digital games, folk games, parasports, history, events, awards, people, science, ideas, the practical guide, reviews, navigation and sources.

Sections (SPT-01 to SPT-34): the main topics, each opening with a *Before you start* box.

Sub-sections and entries (☐): one or two lines each; tick the box when you have played or watched.

Registers: 30 sports, the timeline and 14 world events. They are a sourced selection; the full lists grow on the website.

How to explore it

Step 1. Read Part 0, seven two-minute questions.

Step 2. Find your favourite sport in the master map (Part 1).

Step 3. Visit the folk games of your own state in Part 6.

Step 4. Follow tags and See also links to films, books, music and technology.

Step 5. Tick ☐ as you play or watch, and use the tracker at the end.

Our promise

Knowledge belongs to the people who created it. Every fact here stands on a source listed in Part 17, and every "latest" fact says when it was checked. Where something could not be verified, we say so instead of guessing. Found a mistake? Tell us, and we will fix it and thank you.

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PART 0 — THE INTRODUCTION TWIG: WHY DO HUMANS INVENT GAMES, AND THEN CARE SO MUCH?

About this Part. This is the doorway to the Sports and Games section of the website, in the tree-twig format of the Curious Sparoows library: one Gateway page, seven Leaves and one Recap. Each Leaf answers one question in about two minutes (250 to 400 words), gives its short answer first and ends with a hook to the next question.

SPT-00 The Gateway: Why do humans everywhere invent games with rules that don't matter, and then care about them so much?

Web address: /sports/why-we-play/ · **Keywords:** sports and games, why we play, history of sport, types of sports, Indian games

Nobody needs to put a ball through a hoop. Nobody needs to checkmate a king made of wood. Yet billions of people play, watch and argue about games every day. India stops for a cricket final; Brazil stops for football; a whole hall falls silent for a chess move.

This short course asks one question in seven steps: **why do humans play, and why do games matter so much to us?** It goes from the oldest board game in the world to the Olympics, from chess's journey out of India to esports, and from the science of fandom to the question of what counts as a sport. Each page takes about two minutes.

By the end you will be able to:

- Say what makes something a game, and what makes a game a sport.
- Tell the story of chess from India to the world.
- Explain why the ancient Olympics stopped and how they came back.
- Describe why fans feel a win in their own body.
- Take a side, with reasons, on whether video games are a sport.

SPT-00.01 What was the first game?

> **Short answer:** Running, wrestling and chasing games are surely older than history, because even young animals play-fight. The oldest game we can still play from its own board is the Royal Game of Ur, from Mesopotamia, about 4,600 years old; the Egyptian game senet is older still.

Keywords: first game ever, oldest board game, Royal Game of Ur, senet, history of games

Play is older than humans

Puppies wrestle, crows slide down snowy roofs, and young chimpanzees play chase. Biologists think play trains bodies and brains for real life while keeping everyone safe. So human games began long before anyone wrote them down: races, wrestling, throwing at targets, hide-and-seek.

The oldest boards

- **Senet** (Egypt): boards appear in tombs from about 3100 BCE; Tutankhamun was buried with several.
- **The Royal Game of Ur** (Mesopotamia): beautiful boards found by Leonard Woolley in the Royal Cemetery of Ur, about 2600 BCE. In the 1980s the British Museum curator **Irving Finkel** worked out its rules from a cuneiform tablet written in 177 BCE.
- **Mancala** (Africa and Asia): "count-and-capture" games played with seeds in pits; India's *pallanguzhi* is one.

Games in ancient India

Dice made of bone and the *vibhitaka* nut appear in the Rig Veda's "Gambler's Hymn". The *Mahabharata* turns on a game of dice. Game boards were scratched into the steps of temples and forts.

Remember this: Play is older than humans; the oldest games we can still play were invented in the first cities.

Next: Nearly every culture also invented a ball game. Why the ball?

SPT-00.02 Why does every culture have a ball game?

Short answer: A ball is the simplest object that moves in surprising ways: it rolls, bounces and flies. That makes it perfect for skill, teamwork and chance, so peoples who never met each other invented ball games again and again.

Keywords: history of ball games, Mesoamerican ballgame, cuju, origin of football, why ball games are popular

Many ball games, many places

- **Mesoamerica**: rubber balls from about 1650 BCE; the ballgame (*ōllamaliztli*) was played on stone courts and sometimes linked to ritual sacrifice. Rubber, unknown in Europe then, made balls that bounced high.
- **China**: *cuju* ("kick ball"), played from the Han dynasty; FIFA recognises it as the earliest documented form of football.
- **Japan**: *kemari*, a courtly game of keeping a ball in the air.
- **India**: *gend-balla* and many village ball games; Manipur's *sagol kangjei* (polo on horseback) and *yubi lakpi* (rugby with a greased coconut).
- **North America**: the Haudenosaunee game that the French called *lacrosse*.

Why a ball works

A ball turns physics into drama. It can be passed, so it creates teamwork; it can be stolen, so it creates contest; it can bounce wrongly, so it creates luck. And it is cheap: a bundle of rags, a coconut or a pig's bladder will do.

From folk games to world sports

In 19th-century Britain, schools and clubs wrote down rules: football (1863), rugby (1871), lawn tennis (1870s). Railways, newspapers and the British Empire then carried these rules around the world.

Remember this: The ball is the world's favourite toy because it mixes skill, teamwork and luck.

Next: Some games travelled even further than the ball. The greatest traveller began in India.

SPT-00.03 How did chess travel from India to the world?

Short answer: Chess began in India as *chaturanga* around the 6th century CE, during or just after the Gupta period. It went to Persia as *shatranj*, spread with the Arab world to Europe, and took its modern rules in Spain around 1475, when the queen became the strongest piece.

Keywords: origin of chess, chaturanga, shatranj, history of chess, chess in India

Chaturanga: a model army

Chaturanga means "four limbs", the four divisions of an Indian army: infantry, cavalry, elephants and chariots. These became the pawn, knight, bishop and rook. Its king was the *raja*, with a counsellor beside him.

Persia and the Arab world

By the 7th century the game was played in Sassanid Persia as *chatrang*, later *shatranj*. The Persian *Shahnameh* tells how an Indian king sent it as a riddle to the Persian court. Words came with it: "check" from the Persian *shah* (king), "checkmate" from *shah mat* (the king is helpless).

Europe and the modern queen

Shatranj entered Europe through Muslim Spain and Sicily around 1000 CE. Around 1475, Spanish and Italian players made the queen and the bishop long-range pieces; the faster game was called "the queen's chess".

Back home

Chess also travelled east to become Chinese *xiangqi*, Japanese *shogi* and Thai *makruk*. In 2024 India won both gold medals at the Chess Olympiad and **D. Gukesh** became the youngest undisputed world champion at 18. The game came home.

Remember this: Chaturanga's army of four parts became the world's most played thinking game.

Next: Chess spread for 1,500 years. The Olympics, by contrast, vanished for 1,500 years. Why?

SPT-00.04 Why did the Olympics stop for 1,500 years?

Short answer: The ancient Olympic Games at Olympia (by tradition from 776 BCE) were a religious festival for Zeus. When the Roman Empire became Christian, pagan festivals were banned, and the Games ended around 393 CE. Pierre de Coubertin revived them in Athens in 1896.

Keywords: ancient Olympics, why Olympics ended, Pierre de Coubertin, first modern Olympics 1896

The ancient Games

Every four years Greek city-states held a truce so athletes could travel safely to Olympia. Events included running, wrestling, boxing, the pentathlon, chariot racing and the brutal *pankration*. Winners got an olive wreath, and fame. Married women were not allowed to watch.

The end

Emperor **Theodosius I** banned pagan cults in the 390s; the traditional date for the last ancient Games is 393 CE, though some scholars think they lingered into the 5th century. Earthquakes and floods later buried the site.

The revival

The Frenchman **Pierre de Coubertin** believed sport could build character and peace between nations. He founded the **International Olympic Committee** in 1894; the first modern Games were held in **Athens in 1896**, with 241 athletes, all men. Women competed from 1900 (Paris); the British tennis player Charlotte Cooper was the first woman Olympic champion.

India and the Olympics

Norman Pritchard won two silver medals in athletics for India in 1900. India sent its first official team in 1920 and won its first hockey gold in 1928.

Remember this: The Olympics were sacred, then forbidden, then reborn as a world festival.

Next: The Olympics include some surprising events. So what makes a sport a sport?

SPT-00.05 What makes a sport a sport?

Short answer: Most definitions agree that a sport is a game of skill, with physical effort, rules and fair competition, organised by a governing body. The edges are fuzzy: chess, darts and esports call themselves sports too, and the IOC recognises chess and bridge as "sports of the mind".

Keywords: definition of sport, what is a sport, is chess a sport, game vs sport

Game, play and sport

- **Play** is free activity done for its own sake.
- A **game** adds rules and a goal. The philosopher **Bernard Suits** defined it as "the voluntary attempt to overcome unnecessary obstacles": golf would be easier if you could carry the ball to the hole.
- A **sport** is a game where skill is tested, usually with the body, in organised competition.

The tests people use

1. Is there physical skill or effort?

2. Are there fixed rules and a fair way to decide the winner?
3. Is there a governing body and regular competition?
4. Does skill matter more than luck?

Football passes every test. Snakes and Ladders fails test 4. Chess fails test 1 for some people and passes it for others, because elite chess is physically exhausting. The IOC has recognised chess (FIDE, since 1999) and bridge (the World Bridge Federation) as sports.

Why it matters

Recognition brings money, school places, Olympic dreams and government support. That is why yoga, kabaddi, kho-kho, esports and mallakhamb have all argued to be counted.

Remember this: A sport is skill plus rules plus fair competition; the borders are argued, not fixed.

Next: Whatever counts as a sport, fans feel it in their bodies. Why?

SPT-00.06 Why do fans feel a win in their own body?

Short answer: Fans identify with their team, so the brain treats its wins and losses partly as their own. Heart rate and stress hormones rise during big matches, and a win can feel like personal success. Psychologists call it "basking in reflected glory".

Keywords: sports fan psychology, why fans care, basking in reflected glory, fandom science

"We won", "they lost"

In a famous study (Robert Cialdini and colleagues, 1976), American students wore more university clothing after their football team won, and said "we won", but "they lost" after a defeat. This is **BIRGing** (Basking In Reflected Glory) and its opposite, **CORFing** (Cutting Off Reflected Failure).

The body joins in

Studies of football fans have found raised heart rates and stress hormones during penalty shoot-outs; hospital visits for heart trouble rose in Germany on the days of tense 2006 World Cup matches (Wilbert-Lampen and colleagues, 2008). Fans' brains respond to their team's success in reward areas.

Belonging

Fandom gives people a tribe, a calendar of rituals and shared memories across generations. A grandfather and grandchild may have little in common, except the 1983 or 2011 World Cup.

The dark side

The same feelings can turn into hatred of rivals, violence and online abuse of players. Healthy fandom keeps the joy and lets go of the hate.

Remember this: Fans borrow the team's glory and pain, because belonging is part of being human.

Next: Millions now watch people play video games. Is that a sport?

SPT-00.07 Are video games a sport?

Short answer: Competitive video gaming, called **esports**, has leagues, teams, coaches, prize money and fans in the hundreds of millions, and it was a medal event at the 2022 Asian Games. Whether it is a "sport" depends on the definition; it is certainly a skill competition.

Keywords: are esports a sport, esports Asian Games, gaming as a career, esports in India

What esports is

Professional players compete in games such as *League of Legends*, *Dota 2*, *Counter-Strike*, *Valorant*, *FIFA/EA Sports FC* and, in India, *BGMI* and *Free Fire*. The finals fill stadiums. The first known video-game tournament was held at Stanford University in 1972 (*Spacewar!*).

For

Elite players need fast reactions, hand-eye skill, teamwork, strategy and training of eight hours or more a day. Esports were a demonstration event at the 2018 Asian Games and medal events in 2022 (Hangzhou). The IOC has announced plans for Olympic esports events.

Against

The physical effort is small compared with running or wrestling; the games are owned by companies, which can change or end them; and there are worries about screen time, addiction and gambling.

In India

India's Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Act, 2025 bans real-money online games while promoting esports and social games. Esports is a growing career, but a narrow one: only a few make a living.

Remember this: Esports is skill competition at a high level; whether it is "sport" is a definition fight.

Next: The Recap puts the whole story on one page.

SPT-00.08 Recap: the story of sports and games in one page

Short answer: Humans play because play trains us, bonds us and delights us. Games began with races and wrestling, grew into board games in the first cities, ball games on every continent, codified sports in 19th-century Britain, the modern Olympics in 1896, and digital games today.

Keywords: history of sports summary, sports explained, types of games

1. **Play** is older than humans.
2. **First boards**: senet and the Royal Game of Ur (about 3000–2600 BCE).
3. **Ancient festivals**: Olympia (776 BCE), Mesoamerican ballgames, Indian dice and chaturanga.
4. **Codification** (19th century): football, rugby, tennis, badminton and many others get written rules and governing bodies.
5. **Modern Olympics** (1896), then world championships, leagues, TV and money.
6. **Women's sport and parasports** grow through the 20th and 21st centuries.
7. **Digital games and esports** (from 1972).

Remember this: Games have rules that don't "matter", which is exactly why they can teach us what does.

Next: Part 1 sets out the master map of all sports and games.

PART 1 — THE MASTER MAP OF SPORTS AND GAMES

About this Part. The whole hierarchy on one page, so every sport and game has an address. The website follows the same tree. Each branch below opens into its own Part.

SPT-01 The hierarchy: from Forest to Leaf

Before you start — SPT-01. The Forest is "Sports and Games". It splits into five Trees: physical sports (outdoor and indoor), mind games, digital games, traditional and folk games, and parasports. A sport can sit in two places (kabaddi is both a folk game and a world-championship sport); the website links both. **See also:** SPT-00.05 (what makes a sport).

- ☐ **SPT-01.1 Physical sports, outdoor**: team ball games, bat-and-ball, racket sports on open courts, athletics, water, winter, motor, air, adventure and extreme, equestrian, target sports, and outdoor combat (Part 2).
- ☐ **SPT-01.2 Physical sports, indoor**: indoor court and racket games, gymnastics and strength sports, combat and martial arts, cue sports, bowling and darts, indoor athletics (Part 3).
- ☐ **SPT-01.3 Mind games**: board games, card games, tile games, puzzles, word games and quizzes (Part 4).
- ☐ **SPT-01.4 Digital games**: video game genres, platforms and esports (Part 5).
- ☐ **SPT-01.5 Traditional and folk games**: India state by state and the world (Part 6).
- ☐ **SPT-01.6 Parasports and inclusive games** (Part 7).
- ☐ **SPT-01.7 Across every branch**: history (Part 8), events (Part 9), awards (Part 10), people (Part 11), science (Part 12), ideas (Part 13), the practical guide (Part 14) and reviews (Part 15).

PART 2 — PHYSICAL SPORTS: OUTDOOR

About this Part. Every main outdoor sport, with what it is, where it began, who governs it and where it is popular, in one or two lines. "Olympic" means it is on the programme of the Summer or Winter Games; check olympics.com for each edition. The Sport Register (SPT-13.5) gives full record fields for 30 sports.

SPT-02 Team ball games

Before you start — SPT-02. Many team ball games share one family tree: the folk football of medieval Europe split in 19th-century England into association football (soccer) and rugby, which in turn gave rise to American, Canadian and Australian codes. Hockey and its cousins are stick-and-ball games.

☐ SPT-02.1 Football codes

☐ **Association football (soccer)**: two teams of 11; rules set by the Football Association, London, 1863; governed by **FIFA** (founded Paris, 1904) and the IFAB (law-makers, 1886); the world's most popular sport. Olympic.

☐ **Futsal and beach soccer**: five-a-side indoor football (FIFA) and sand football.

☐ **Rugby union**: 15 players; the "William Webb Ellis ran with the ball at Rugby School, 1823" story is a legend; Rugby Football Union 1871; **World Rugby**. Rugby sevens is Olympic (since 2016).

☐ **Rugby league**: 13 players; split from union in 1895 in northern England over payments to players.

☐ **American football**: from rugby and soccer at US colleges (1869 onward); Walter Camp's rules; the NFL (1920) and the Super Bowl (1967).

☐ **Canadian football**, **Australian rules football** (Melbourne, 1859; the AFL), **Gaelic football** (Ireland; the GAA, 1884).

☐ SPT-02.2 Stick and ball

☐ **Field hockey**: 11 a side, stick and hard ball; modern rules in England (1886); **FIH** (1924); India won eight Olympic golds (1928–1956, 1964, 1980) and bronze in 2020 and 2024. Olympic.

☐ **Ice hockey**: see SPT-07. **Bandy**: hockey on ice with a ball (Russia, Sweden).

☐ **Hurling and camogie** (Ireland, ancient): fast game with a *hurley* and *sliotar*.

☐ **Lacrosse**: from the Haudenosaunee and other First Nations; returns to the Olympics at Los Angeles 2028 (sixes).

☐ **Polo**: modern polo was learned by British officers from Manipur (*sagol kangjei*) in the 1850s–60s; the **Calcutta Polo Club** (1862) is among the oldest in the world. See SPT-09.

☐ **Shinty** (Scotland) and **golf** (see SPT-09).

☐ SPT-02.3 Hand and net team games played outdoors

☐ **Beach volleyball** (Olympic since 1996), **Gaelic handball**, **ultimate frisbee** (flying disc, self-refereed "spirit of the game"), **flag football** (non-contact American football, Olympic from 2028), **tchoukball**.

☐ **Kabaddi and kho-kho**: Indian team chase games played outdoors and indoors; see SPT-17.

SPT-03 Bat-and-ball games

Before you start — SPT-03. Bat-and-ball games share a pattern: one side bats and scores runs, the other bowls or pitches and fields. Cricket, baseball and rounders may have common roots in English folk games such as stoolball.

☐ **SPT-03.1 Cricket**: 11 a side; England, 16th century; the Laws are kept by the **MCC** (from 1788); governed by the **ICC** (founded 1909 as the Imperial Cricket Conference; HQ Dubai). Formats: Test (first Test, Melbourne, 1877), One-Day International (1971; first World Cup 1975, won by West Indies), Twenty20 (2003; first T20 World Cup 2007, won by India). Returns to the Olympics at Los Angeles 2028 (T20). India's men won the T20 World Cup in 2007, 2024 and **2026** (final against New Zealand, 8 March 2026), the ODI World Cup in 1983 and 2011, and the Champions Trophy in 2002 (shared), 2013 and 2025; India's women won their first ODI World Cup in **2025**.

☐ **SPT-03.2 Leagues**: the **Indian Premier League** (2008; Royal Challengers Bengaluru won in 2025 and **2026**), Big Bash (Australia), The Hundred (England), Women's Premier League (India, 2023), Pakistan Super League, Caribbean Premier League.

☐ **SPT-03.3 Baseball**: 9 a side; from English bat-and-ball games, shaped in New York (the Knickerbocker rules, 1845); Major League Baseball (1903 World Series); hugely popular in the USA, Japan, Korea, Cuba, the Dominican Republic; World Baseball Classic (2006). Olympic at some Games (returns 2028).

☐ **SPT-03.4 Softball**: larger ball, underarm pitching; Olympic at some Games.

☐ **SPT-03.5 Rounders** (Britain, Ireland), **stoolball** (England), **pesäpallo** (Finnish baseball), **lapta** (Russia).

☐ **SPT-03.6 Gilli-danda and street cricket**: India's stick-and-peg game and the *gully cricket* of lanes and rooftops (see SPT-17).

SPT-04 Racket sports on open courts

Before you start — SPT-04. Racket sports grew from the medieval French *jeu de paume* ("game of the palm") and real tennis. Lawn tennis was patented in 1874. Badminton, table tennis and squash are mostly indoor and appear in SPT-10.

☐ **SPT-04.1 Tennis**: singles or doubles on grass, clay or hard courts; Major Walter Clopton Wingfield's *sphairistike* (1873–74); the first **Wimbledon** (1877, won by Spencer Gore); the four Grand Slams (Australian Open, Roland-Garros, Wimbledon, US Open); **ITF** (1913), ATP and WTA tours; Davis Cup (1900), Billie Jean King Cup. Olympic. Indian stars: Ramanathan Krishnan, Vijay Amritraj, Leander Paes (Olympic bronze 1996), Mahesh Bhupathi, Sania Mirza, Rohan Bopanna.

☐ **SPT-04.2 Real tennis (court tennis)**: the indoor ancestor, still played in a few historic courts.

☐ **SPT-04.3 Padel**: doubles in a walled court (Mexico, 1969); fast-growing in Spain, Argentina and the Gulf.

☐ **SPT-04.4 Pickleball**: paddle game invented on Bainbridge Island, Washington (1965); the fastest-growing sport in the USA in the 2020s.

☐ **SPT-04.5 Beach tennis, platform tennis, soft tennis** (Japan, Korea).

SPT-05 Athletics (track and field, road and cross-country)

Before you start — SPT-05. "Athletics" is the oldest sport family: run, jump, throw. **World Athletics** (founded 1912 as the IAAF) governs it. It is the heart of the Olympic programme.

☐ **SPT-05.1 Sprints and hurdles**: 100 m to 400 m; Usain Bolt's 100 m world record of 9.58 s (Berlin, 2009); Florence Griffith-Joyner's 10.49 s (1988).

☐ **SPT-05.2 Middle and long distance**: 800 m to 10,000 m, steeplechase; the "four-minute mile" broken by **Roger Bannister** (1954).

☐ **SPT-05.3 Marathon and road running**: from the legend of Pheidippides; the distance was fixed at 42.195 km in 1921 (from the 1908 London Olympics course); Eliud Kipchoge's sub-two-hour run (an unofficial event, Vienna 2019); Mumbai Marathon (2004).

☐ **SPT-05.4 Relays**: 4 × 100 m, 4 × 400 m, mixed relays.

☐ **SPT-05.5 Jumps**: high jump (the Fosbury Flop, 1968), pole vault (Armand Duplantis's repeated world records), long jump, triple jump.

☐ **SPT-05.6 Throws**: shot put, discus, hammer, javelin. **Neeraj Chopra** won India's first Olympic gold in athletics (javelin, Tokyo 2020), silver at Paris 2024 and the 2023 world title.

☐ **SPT-05.7 Combined events**: decathlon (men), heptathlon (women).

☐ **SPT-05.8 Race walking, cross-country, trail and ultra running, mountain running**.

☐ **SPT-05.9 Indian athletics legends**: Milkha Singh ("The Flying Sikh"), P. T. Usha (fourth in the 400 m hurdles, 1984, by 1/100 of a second), Anju Bobby George (world championship bronze, 2003), Hima Das, Avinash Sable.

SPT-06 Water sports

Before you start — SPT-06. Water sports include racing in, on and under water. **World Aquatics** (founded 1908 as FINA)

governs swimming, diving, water polo, artistic and open-water swimming.

- ☐ **SPT-06.1 Swimming**: freestyle, backstroke, breaststroke, butterfly, medley; Michael Phelps won 23 Olympic golds; Katie Ledecky; Indian swimmers Mihir Sen (Palk Strait, 1966), Sajan Prakash, Srihari Nataraj.
- ☐ **SPT-06.2 Diving, artistic swimming, water polo, open-water marathon swimming**.
- ☐ **SPT-06.3 Rowing**: the Oxford–Cambridge Boat Race (1829); World Rowing; Olympic.
- ☐ **SPT-06.4 Canoe and kayak**: sprint and slalom; dragon boat racing (China).
- ☐ **SPT-06.5 Sailing**: dinghies, keelboats, windsurfing and kitefoiling; the America's Cup (1851), the oldest international trophy in sport.
- ☐ **SPT-06.6 Surfing**: from ancient Hawaii (*he'e nalu*); Duke Kahanamoku; Olympic from 2020; India's surfing coast at Mulki (Karnataka) and Kovalam.
- ☐ **SPT-06.7 Traditional boat races**: Kerala's **vallam kali** snake-boat races (the Nehru Trophy on Punnamada Lake since 1952); Indonesia's *pacu jalur*.
- ☐ **SPT-06.8 Other water sports**: water skiing, wakeboarding, jet ski, underwater hockey, free diving, fishing (sport angling).

SPT-07 Winter sports

Before you start — SPT-07. Snow and ice sports grew in Scandinavia, the Alps and North America. The first Winter Olympics were at Chamonix (1924). At **Milano Cortina 2026** (6–22 February 2026) Norway topped the medal table.

- ☐ **SPT-07.1 Skiing**: alpine (downhill, slalom), Nordic (cross-country), ski jumping, freestyle, biathlon (skiing plus shooting); governed by FIS.
- ☐ **SPT-07.2 Snowboarding**: from the 1960s–70s "snurfer"; Olympic since 1998.
- ☐ **SPT-07.3 Skating**: figure skating, speed skating, short track; ISU (1892).
- ☐ **SPT-07.4 Ice hockey**: Montreal, 1875 (first organised indoor game); NHL (1917); Canada, USA, Russia, Sweden, Finland, Czechia.
- ☐ **SPT-07.5 Sliding sports**: bobsleigh, luge, skeleton; India's Shiva Keshavan competed in luge at six Winter Olympics.
- ☐ **SPT-07.6 Curling**: Scotland, 16th century; "chess on ice".
- ☐ **SPT-07.7 Winter sports in India**: Gulmarg and Auli for skiing; the Khelo India Winter Games (since 2020) in Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh; ice hockey in Ladakh.

SPT-08 Motor sports and air sports

Before you start — SPT-08. Motor sports race cars, bikes, boats and more; the **FIA** (cars, 1904) and **FIM** (motorcycles, 1904) govern most. Air sports are governed by the **FAI** (1905).

- ☐ **SPT-08.1 Formula One**: the world championship began in 1950 (first race at Silverstone; first champion Giuseppe Farina); Michael Schumacher and Lewis Hamilton each won seven titles; Lando Norris won the 2025 title. India hosted the Indian Grand Prix at the Buddh International Circuit (2011–2013); Narain Karthikeyan (2005) and Karun Chandhok are India's F1 drivers.
- ☐ **SPT-08.2 Other car racing**: endurance (24 Hours of Le Mans, 1923), IndyCar (Indianapolis 500, 1911), NASCAR, rallying (WRC; the Dakar Rally), touring cars, karting, Formula E (electric, 2014).
- ☐ **SPT-08.3 Motorcycle racing**: MotoGP (world championship since 1949), Isle of Man TT (1907), motocross, speedway, superbike; India's Harith Noah and C. S. Santosh at the Dakar.
- ☐ **SPT-08.4 Powerboat racing and air racing**.
- ☐ **SPT-08.5 Air sports**: gliding, paragliding (Bir Billing, Himachal, hosted the Paragliding World Cup in 2015), hang gliding, skydiving, ballooning, aerobatics, drone racing.

SPT-09 Adventure, equestrian and target sports

Before you start — SPT-09. Three outdoor families: adventure and extreme (pushing against nature), equestrian (horse

and rider together), and target (precision).

☐ SPT-09.1 Adventure and extreme

☐ **Mountaineering**: Everest first climbed by **Edmund Hillary and Tenzing Norgay** (29 May 1953); Bachendri Pal the first Indian woman on top (1984); Arunima Sinha the first woman amputee (2013).

☐ **Sport climbing** (Olympic since 2020), bouldering, trekking, orienteering.

☐ **Triathlon** (1974 onward; Olympic since 2000) and the Ironman (Hawaii, 1978); duathlon, adventure racing.

☐ **Cycling**: road (Tour de France, 1903), track, mountain bike, BMX; UCI (1900).

☐ **Skateboarding** (Olympic since 2020), parkour, inline skating, roller sports.

☐ **Extreme sports**: base jumping, wingsuit flying, big-wave surfing, ice climbing; the X Games (1995).

☐ SPT-09.2 Equestrian

☐ **Olympic equestrian**: dressage, show jumping, eventing; men and women compete together; FEI (1921).

☐ **Polo** (see SPT-02.2) and **horse racing** (the Derby at Epsom, 1780; the Indian Derby, Mumbai; flat racing, steeplechase).

☐ **Endurance riding, vaulting, tent pegging** (cavalry sport popular in India and Pakistan), **buzkashi** (Central Asia).

☐ SPT-09.3 Target sports

☐ **Archery**: World Archery (1931); Olympic; Korea's dominance; India's Deepika Kumari; **Sheetal Devi** in para archery (SPT-19).

☐ **Shooting**: rifle, pistol, shotgun; ISSF; **Abhinav Bindra** won India's first individual Olympic gold (10 m air rifle, Beijing 2008); **Manu Bhaker** won two bronzes at Paris 2024, the first Indian to win two medals at one Games after independence.

☐ **Golf**: Scotland, 15th century; St Andrews; the R&A and USGA set rules; the four men's majors (The Masters, PGA Championship, US Open, The Open); Olympic again since 2016; Aditi Ashok fourth at Tokyo 2020.

☐ **Bowls (lawn bowls), pétanque, bocce, croquet, disc golf**: precision games of rolling and throwing.

PART 3 — PHYSICAL SPORTS: INDOOR

About this Part. Sports usually played under a roof: court and racket games, gymnastics and strength, combat and martial arts, cue sports, bowling and darts. Several (volleyball, kabaddi, futsal) are played both indoors and out.

SPT-10 Indoor court and racket games

Before you start — SPT-10. Several of these were invented on purpose by teachers or officers who needed a game for a hall or a rainy season.

- ☐ **SPT-10.1 Badminton**: shuttlecock over a high net; played by British officers in **Poona (Pune)** in the 1870s, named after the Duke of Beaufort's Badminton House; **BWF** (founded 1934 as the IBF); the All England Championships (1899); Olympic since 1992. India: Prakash Padukone (All England 1980), Pullela Gopichand (All England 2001), Saina Nehwal (Olympic bronze 2012), **P. V. Sindhu** (Olympic silver 2016, bronze 2020; world champion 2019), Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty, Lakshya Sen.
- ☐ **SPT-10.2 Table tennis**: "ping-pong" from Victorian England (1880s); **ITTF** (1926); Olympic since 1988; China's dominance; the "Ping-Pong Diplomacy" between the USA and China (1971); India's Sharath Kamal, Manika Batra.
- ☐ **SPT-10.3 Squash**: from Harrow School, England (about 1830); World Squash, PSA tour; joins the Olympics at Los Angeles 2028; India's Saurav Ghosal, Joshna Chinappa, Dipika Pallikal.
- ☐ **SPT-10.4 Basketball**: invented by **James Naismith** in Springfield, Massachusetts (December 1891) with peach baskets; **FIBA** (1932); the NBA (1946); 3×3 basketball is Olympic since 2020.
- ☐ **SPT-10.5 Volleyball**: invented by **William G. Morgan** in Holyoke, Massachusetts (1895) as "Mintonette"; FIVB (1947); Olympic since 1964; huge in Brazil, Italy, Poland, Japan; Kerala's village volleyball culture.
- ☐ **SPT-10.6 Handball**: Denmark and Germany, around 1900; IHF; Olympic; very popular in Europe.
- ☐ **SPT-10.7 Netball**: from early women's basketball (1890s); strong in England, Australia, New Zealand, Jamaica; Commonwealth Games sport.
- ☐ **SPT-10.8 Futsal, floorball, korfball** (Dutch mixed-gender game), **sepak takraw** (kick volleyball of South-East Asia; also outdoors), **throwball** (India), **tenniquoit (ring tennis)**.

SPT-11 Gymnastics, strength and fitness sports

Before you start — SPT-11. Sports of the body's control and power. Gymnastics comes from the German *Turnen* movement of Friedrich Ludwig Jahn (1810s); **FIG** (1881) is the oldest international sports federation still in existence.

- ☐ **SPT-11.1 Artistic gymnastics**: floor, vault, bars, beam, rings, pommel horse; Nadia Comăneci's first perfect 10 (1976); Simone Biles; India's Dipa Karmakar (fourth in vault, Rio 2016).
- ☐ **SPT-11.2 Rhythmic gymnastics, trampoline, acrobatic and aerobic gymnastics, parkour (FIG discipline)**.
- ☐ **SPT-11.3 Mallakhamb**: Indian pole and rope gymnastics from Maharashtra; revived by Balambhatdada Deodhar in the 19th century; now in the National Games and Khelo India; also SPT-17.
- ☐ **SPT-11.4 Weightlifting**: snatch, clean and jerk; Olympic; **Karnam Malleswari** (bronze 2000, the first Indian woman to win an Olympic medal) and **Mirabai Chanu** (silver, Tokyo 2020).
- ☐ **SPT-11.5 Powerlifting, strongman, bodybuilding, CrossFit, arm wrestling**: strength competitions outside the Olympics.
- ☐ **SPT-11.6 Yoga as sport (yogasana)**: competitive yogasana is in Khelo India and the National Games; International Yoga Day (21 June, since 2015).
- ☐ **SPT-11.7 Dance sport**: ballroom and **breaking** (breakdance, Olympic only at Paris 2024).

SPT-12 Combat sports and martial arts

Before you start — SPT-12. Combat sports have the oldest roots of all (wrestling is in the earliest art). Many Asian martial arts are also philosophies of self-discipline.

☐ **SPT-12.1 Wrestling**: freestyle and Greco-Roman; **United World Wrestling**; Indian **kushti** in the *akhara* (mud pit), Great Gama (undefeated in the early 20th century); **Khashaba Dadasaheb Jadhav** won independent India's first individual Olympic medal (bronze, Helsinki 1952); Sushil Kumar (2008, 2012), Sakshi Malik (2016), Bajrang Punia, Ravi Dahiya, Aman Sehrawat (bronze, 2024).

☐ **SPT-12.2 Boxing**: modern rules from the Marquess of Queensberry (1867); amateur and professional; Muhammad Ali; India's **M. C. Mary Kom** (six-time world champion, Olympic bronze 2012), Vijender Singh (2008), Lovlina Borgohain (2020), Nikhat Zareen.

☐ **SPT-12.3 Judo**: founded by **Kanō Jigorō** at the Kodokan, Tokyo (1882); Olympic since 1964.

☐ **SPT-12.4 Karate** (Okinawa), **taekwondo** (Korea; Olympic since 2000), **kung fu / wushu** (China; Asian Games), **aikido**, **kendo**, **sumo** (Japan's national sport), **jiu-jitsu** (Brazilian jiu-jitsu).

☐ **SPT-12.5 Fencing**: foil, épée, sabre; from duelling schools; Olympic since 1896; **Bhavani Devi** was India's first Olympic fencer (2021).

☐ **SPT-12.6 Kickboxing, Muay Thai, savate, sambo, MMA** (mixed martial arts; the UFC since 1993).

☐ **SPT-12.7 Indian martial arts**: **kalaripayattu** (Kerala; with weapons and healing), **silambam** (Tamil Nadu, staff), **thang-ta** (Manipur, sword and spear), **gatka** (Punjab, Sikh), **mardani khel** (Maharashtra), **lathi khela** (Bengal), **pari-khanda** (Bihar); several are in the Khelo India Games.

SPT-13 Cue sports, bowling, darts and indoor athletics

Before you start — SPT-13. Precision games of the club, the pub and the hall. Snooker was invented in India.

☐ **SPT-13.1 Billiards**: English billiards, carom (French), pool (American, eight-ball and nine-ball); India's **Pankaj Advani** has won more than 25 world titles in billiards and snooker; Wilson Jones (world amateur billiards champion, 1958) and Geet Sethi.

☐ **SPT-13.2 Snooker**: devised by British army officers at **Jabalpur** in 1875 (credited to the young officer Neville Chamberlain, later Colonel Sir Neville Chamberlain, not the prime minister) and codified at Ootacamund (Ooty) in 1882; the World Championship at the Crucible, Sheffield (since 1977).

☐ **SPT-13.3 Ten-pin bowling, nine-pin, duckpin, candlepin**; World Bowling.

☐ **SPT-13.4 Darts**: England; the PDC and WDF world championships; huge TV following.

☐ **SPT-13.5 Indoor athletics, indoor rowing, indoor cycling, climbing walls, table football (foosball), air hockey**.

☐ SPT-13.6 The Sport Register: 30 landmark sports

How to read it. Each row gives the record fields of the brief: sport, category path, origin, governing body, players and field, Olympic status and biggest events. Legends appear in Part 11. Dates are as stated by the governing bodies.

Sport	Category path	Origin (place, year)	Governing body	Players · field or equipment	Olympic status · biggest events
Football (soccer)	Outdoor › team ball › football codes	England, rules 1863	FIFA (1904)	11 a side · grass pitch, ball	Olympic · FIFA World Cup (1930)
Cricket	Outdoor › bat-and-ball	England, 16th c.; Laws 1788	ICC (1909)	11 a side · oval, 22-yard pitch	Olympic in 1900 and from 2028 · ODI and T20 World Cups
Field hockey	Outdoor › stick and ball	England, rules 1886	FIH (1924)	11 a side · turf, stick, ball	Olympic · Hockey World Cup (1971)
Rugby union	Outdoor › football codes	England, RFU 1871	World Rugby (1886)	15 a side (7s) · pitch, oval ball	Sevens Olympic · Rugby World Cup (1987)
Basketball	Indoor › court	Springfield, USA, 1891	FIBA (1932)	5 a side · court, hoops	Olympic · FIBA World Cup, NBA
Volleyball	Indoor › court	Holyoke, USA, 1895	FIVB (1947)	6 a side · court, net	Olympic · World Championship
Tennis	Outdoor › racket	England, 1873–74	ITF (1913)	1 or 2 a side · court, racket	Olympic · four Grand Slams
Badminton	Indoor › racket	Pune, India, 1870s	BWF (1934)	1 or 2 a side · court,	Olympic (1992) · World

				shuttle	Championships, All England
Table tennis	Indoor › racket	England, 1880s	ITTF (1926)	1 or 2 a side · table, paddle	Olympic (1988) · World Championships
Squash	Indoor › racket	Harrow, England, c. 1830	World Squash	1 a side · walled court	Olympic from 2028 · World Championships
Athletics	Outdoor › athletics	Ancient; modern 19th c.	World Athletics (1912)	Individual, relays · track, field	Olympic · World Championships (1983)
Swimming	Outdoor/indoor › water	Ancient; modern 19th c.	World Aquatics (1908)	Individual, relays · pool	Olympic · World Championships
Rowing	Outdoor › water	England, 18th–19th c.	World Rowing (1892)	1 to 9 · boat, oars	Olympic · World Championships, The Boat Race
Cycling	Outdoor › adventure	Europe, 1860s–80s	UCI (1900)	Individual, teams · road, track	Olympic · Tour de France (1903)
Formula One	Outdoor › motor	World championship 1950	FIA (1904)	Drivers, teams · circuit	Not Olympic · F1 World Championship
Skiing	Outdoor › winter	Scandinavia, ancient	FIS (1924)	Individual · snow slopes	Winter Olympic · FIS World Cup
Ice hockey	Indoor/outdoor › winter	Montreal, 1875	IIHF (1908)	6 a side · rink, puck	Winter Olympic · NHL Stanley Cup
Golf	Outdoor › target	Scotland, 15th c.	R&A, USGA, IGF	Individual · 18-hole course	Olympic (2016) · four majors
Archery	Outdoor › target	Ancient	World Archery (1931)	Individual, teams · bow, target	Olympic · World Championships
Shooting	Outdoor/indoor › target	19th c. clubs	ISSF (1907)	Individual · rifle, pistol, shotgun	Olympic · ISSF World Cup
Wrestling	Indoor › combat	Ancient	UWW (1912)	1 v 1 · mat	Olympic · World Championships
Boxing	Indoor › combat	England, rules 1867	World Boxing (2023), pro bodies	1 v 1 · ring	Olympic · World Championships, pro titles
Judo	Indoor › combat	Tokyo, 1882	IJF (1951)	1 v 1 · tatami	Olympic (1964) · World Championships
Gymnastics	Indoor › gymnastics	Germany, 1810s	FIG (1881)	Individual, teams · apparatus	Olympic · World Championships
Weightlifting	Indoor › strength	19th c.	IWF (1905)	Individual · barbell	Olympic · World Championships
Kabaddi	Folk › team chase	India, ancient	IKF; AKFI (India)	7 a side · court	Asian Games (1990) · Kabaddi World Cup, Pro Kabaddi
Kho-kho	Folk › team chase	Maharashtra, codified 1914	International Kho Kho Federation	9 (or 12 squad) · court, poles	Asian Games demonstration · Kho Kho World Cup (2025)
Chess	Mind › board	India, c. 6th c.	FIDE (1924)	1 v 1 · board	IOC-recognised · World Championship, Olympiad
Snooker	Indoor › cue	Jabalpur, India, 1875	WPBSA, IBSF	1 v 1 · table, cue	Not Olympic · World Championship
Esports	Digital › esports	Stanford, 1972	Many publishers; IESF	Teams or solo · screens	Asian Games (2022) · The International, LoL Worlds

PART 4 — MIND GAMES

About this Part. Games won by thinking: board games, cards, tiles, puzzles, words and quizzes. Some are pure skill (chess, Go), some mix skill and luck (backgammon, bridge, poker), and some are pure luck (Snakes and Ladders).

SPT-14 Board games

Before you start — SPT-14. Board games are among the oldest human inventions (SPT-00.01). India gave the world chess, pachisi (Ludo) and Snakes and Ladders.

☐ SPT-14.1 Chess and its family

☐ **Chess**: from Indian *chaturanga* (SPT-00.03); **FIDE** (founded Paris, 1924); the first official world champion was **Wilhelm Steinitz** (1886). **Viswanathan Anand** became India's first grandmaster (1988) and world champion (2000; undisputed 2007–2013). **D. Gukesh** became the youngest undisputed world champion (Singapore, December 2024, aged 18). In April 2026 **Javokhir Sindarov** (Uzbekistan) won the Candidates Tournament to challenge Gukesh, and **R. Vaishali** won the Women's Candidates. India won both gold medals at the 2024 Chess Olympiad (Budapest); **Divya Deshmukh** won the 2025 Women's World Cup.

☐ **Xiangqi** (Chinese chess, with a river and cannons), **shogi** (Japanese chess, where captured pieces return), **makruk** (Thai chess), **janggi** (Korean chess).

☐ **Chess variants**: Chess960 (Fischer Random), blitz and bullet, correspondence chess, chess problems and studies.

☐ SPT-14.2 Strategy games of the world

☐ **Go (weiqi, baduk)**: China, more than 2,500 years old; black and white stones on a 19×19 grid; **AlphaGo** (DeepMind) beat Lee Sedol in 2016, a landmark for AI.

☐ **Draughts (checkers)**, **Reversi/Othello**, **Nine Men's Morris**, **Hex**, **Connect Four**.

☐ **Aadu puli attam (goats and tigers)**: a South Indian hunt game; similar "hunt games" are played across Asia (the Nepali *bagh-chal*).

☐ **Mancala family**: *pallanguzhi* (Tamil Nadu), *oware* (West Africa), *bao* (East Africa).

☐ SPT-14.3 Race and chance board games

☐ **Senet** and the **Royal Game of Ur** (see SPT-00.01).

☐ **Backgammon**: from the Persian *nard*; skill and dice.

☐ **Pachisi and chaupar**: the cross-shaped Indian race game played with cowrie shells; Akbar's giant courtyard board at Fatehpur Sikri. It became **Ludo** (patented in England, 1896) and the American *Parcheesi*.

☐ **Snakes and Ladders**: from the Indian *Moksha Patam / Gyan Chaupar*, a moral game where virtues are ladders and vices are snakes; taken to England in the 1890s.

☐ **Correction from the brief: Chinese checkers is not Chinese.** It was invented in Germany (1892) as *Stern-Halma* and given the name "Chinese checkers" by American marketers in 1928.

☐ SPT-14.4 Modern board games

☐ **Monopoly**: from **Lizzie Magie**'s *The Landlord's Game* (1904), a critique of landlords; sold by Parker Brothers from 1935. India's *Business* (Trade) game is a local version.

☐ **Scrabble** (Alfred Butts, 1938), **Cluedo/Clue** (1949), **Risk** (1957), **Catan** (Klaus Teuber, 1995), **Ticket to Ride**, **Carcassonne**, **Pandemic**: the "Eurogame" boom.

☐ **Carrom**: South Asian finger-flick game; the International Carrom Federation (1988); India and Sri Lanka lead; often played at home and in clubs.

☐ **Tabletop and role-playing games**: *Dungeons & Dragons* (1974), miniature war games.

SPT-15 Cards, tiles, puzzles, words and quizzes

☐ **SPT-15.1 Playing cards**: invented in Tang-dynasty China; spread through the Islamic world (Mamluk cards) to Europe in the 1370s; the French suits (hearts, diamonds, clubs, spades). India's **ganjifa**, round painted cards of the Mughal court and the Dashavatara sets of Odisha and Sawantwadi.

☐ **SPT-15.2 Card games**: bridge (the World Bridge Federation, 1958; a medal sport at the 2018 Asian Games, where India won gold in men's pairs), rummy, teen patti, poker (skill and chance; real-money versions are now banned online in India), solitaire, uno; trading-card games such as *Magic: The Gathering* and *Pokémon*.

☐ **SPT-15.3 Tile games**: **mahjong** (China, 19th century), **dominoes**, **rummikub**.

☐ **SPT-15.4 Puzzles**: the jigsaw (John Spilsbury, London, 1760s, as a geography lesson); the **crossword** (Arthur Wynne, New York World, 1913); **sudoku** (Howard Garns's "Number Place", 1979; named by Nikoli, Japan, 1984); the **Rubik's Cube** (Ernő Rubik, 1974) and speedcubing; tangram (China).

☐ **SPT-15.5 Word games**: Scrabble, Boggle, Wordle (2021), antakshari (the Indian song-chain game), shabd-khoj (word search), riddles (*paheli*).

☐ **SPT-15.6 Quizzes**: *Bournvita Quiz Contest* (Derek O'Brien), *Mastermind India*, *Kaun Banega Crorepati* (2000, from *Who Wants to Be a Millionaire?*), university quiz clubs, the Tata Crucible; quiz master Siddhartha Basu.

☐ **SPT-15.7 Memory and mental sports**: mental calculation, memory championships, the Mind Sports Olympiad.

PART 5 — DIGITAL GAMES AND ESPORTS

About this Part. Video games are the largest entertainment industry in the world by revenue. This Part maps their kinds, platforms and competitive scene. **See also:** TEC (computing), MOV (games and film).

SPT-16 Video games and esports

☐ SPT-16.1 Genres

☐ **Action and platform** (*Super Mario Bros.*, 1985), **adventure**, **role-playing (RPG)** (*The Legend of Zelda*, *Final Fantasy*), **shooter** (first-person: *Doom*, *Counter-Strike*; battle royale: *PUBG*, *Fortnite*, *Free Fire*), **strategy** (real-time: *StarCraft*; turn-based: *Civilization*), **MOBA** (*League of Legends*, *Dota 2*), **sports and racing** (*FIFA/EA Sports FC*, *Gran Turismo*), **fighting** (*Street Fighter*), **puzzle** (*Tetris*, 1984), **simulation and sandbox** (*The Sims*, *Minecraft*), **rhythm**, **horror**, **casual and mobile** (*Candy Crush*, *Ludo King*).

☐ SPT-16.2 Platforms and milestones

☐ **Early**: *Tennis for Two* (1958), *Spacewar!* (1962), *Pong* (Atari, 1972).

☐ **Arcade** (1970s–80s: *Space Invaders*, *Pac-Man*); **home consoles** (Atari 2600, Nintendo Famicom/NES 1983, Sega, Sony PlayStation 1994, Xbox 2001, Nintendo Switch 2017); **PC**; **handhelds** (Game Boy 1989); **mobile** (*Snake* on Nokia phones, 1997; smartphones from 2007); **VR and AR** (*Pokémon Go*, 2016); **cloud gaming**.

☐ **Indian games and studios**: *Ludo King* (Gametion, 2016), *Raji: An Ancient Epic*, Indian mobile studios; *BGMI* (India's version of *PUBG Mobile*).

☐ SPT-16.3 Esports

☐ **Titles and tournaments**: *League of Legends* World Championship, *Dota 2*'s *The International*, *Counter-Strike* Majors, *Valorant* Champions, the FIFAe/EA FC competitions, *BGMI* and *Free Fire* leagues in India.

☐ **Multi-sport events**: demonstration at the 2018 Asian Games; medal events at Hangzhou 2022; the IOC's Olympic Esports plans (check olympics.com for status).

☐ **Careers**: players, coaches, analysts, casters, streamers, game designers; most earn modestly; a few earn millions.

☐ **India's law**: the Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Act, 2025 bans real-money online games and sets up support for esports and social games.

☐ SPT-16.4 Healthy gaming

☐ WHO lists **gaming disorder** in ICD-11 (2019) for severe cases; most players are not affected. Healthy habits: time limits, breaks, sleep first, play with people you know, no gambling-like spending (SPT-29).

PART 6 — TRADITIONAL AND FOLK GAMES

About this Part. The games of villages, streets and festivals, many of them centuries old. Some became world sports (kabaddi, polo, badminton); many are fading and need recording. **See also:** CRO/KNT (traditional crafts), the Curriculum Index (Art and Culture).

SPT-17 Traditional games of India

Before you start — SPT-17. India's traditional games need almost no equipment: a stick, a few stones, a line on the ground. The government's **Khelo India** programme (2018) and the Fit India Movement (2019) have brought several into schools. Names change from region to region; the common name comes first.

☐ SPT-17.1 Team chase and tag games

- ☐ **Kabaddi**: two teams of seven; a raider crosses the line, tags opponents and must return in one breath while chanting "kabaddi"; ancient roots in Tamil Nadu and Punjab (forms: Sanjeevani, Gaminee, Amar, Punjabi circle style); Asian Games since 1990 (Iran won the men's gold in 2018; India regained it in 2022); **Pro Kabaddi League** (2014).
- ☐ **Kho-kho**: a chase game of nine where chasers sit in a line facing opposite ways and "kho" (tag) a teammate to run; rules first written at Pune's Deccan Gymkhana (1914); India won both the men's and women's titles at the first **Kho Kho World Cup** (New Delhi, January 2025); Ultimate Kho Kho league (2022).
- ☐ **Atya-patya** (Maharashtra), **langdi** (hopping tag), **chor-police**, **chhupan-chhupai** (hide and seek), **oonch-neech** ("high and low").

☐ SPT-17.2 Stick, stone and marble games

- ☐ **Gilli-danda**: a small wooden peg (*gilli*) struck with a stick (*danda*), a cousin of cricket and the "tip-cat" of Europe; called *kitti-pullu* in Tamil Nadu and *chinni-dandu* in Andhra Pradesh.
- ☐ **Pitthu / lagori / sat-tolia** (seven stones): one team knocks down a stack of stones with a ball and rebuilds it while the other team tries to hit them.
- ☐ **Kanche (marbles, goti)**, **lattoo (spinning top)**, **gutte / pallanguzhi** (five stones and seed-pit games), **stapu** (hopscotch, *kith-kith*), **kite flying** (*patangbazi*; Uttarayan in Gujarat, 14 January).

☐ SPT-17.3 Strength, wrestling and martial games

- ☐ **Kushti / pehlwani** in the akhara (SPT-12.1); **mallakhamb** (SPT-11.3); **kalaripayattu**, **silambam**, **thang-ta**, **gatka** (SPT-12.7); **inbuan** (Mizo wrestling); **mukna** (Manipuri wrestling); **tug of war** (*rassa-kashi*; Olympic 1900–1920).

☐ SPT-17.4 Animal and water festival sports

- ☐ **Vallam kali** (Kerala snake-boat races, SPT-06.7); **kambala** (Karnataka buffalo race in paddy fields); **jallikattu** (Tamil Nadu bull-taming, upheld by the Supreme Court in 2023 under the state's amended law); **bullock-cart races** (Maharashtra, Punjab); **camel races** (Pushkar and Bikaner fairs).
- ☐ **Ethics note**: animal sports raise welfare questions; courts and laws have changed several times; the website presents both the cultural case and the welfare case.

☐ SPT-17.5 Regional games and festivals

- ☐ **Manipur**: *sagol kangjei* (polo), *yubi lakpi* (coconut rugby), *khong kangjei* (hockey on foot).
- ☐ **Punjab**: the **Kila Raipur Rural Olympics** (near Ludhiana, since 1933), with bullock-cart races and strength events; *kabaddi* circle style.
- ☐ **Himachal Pradesh**: *thoda* (a folk archery battle from the Mahabharata).
- ☐ **Rajasthan and Gujarat**: *kabaddi*, kite flying, *chaupar* (SPT-14.3).
- ☐ **North-east**: Naga wrestling, Mizo *inbuan*, Assam's *dhopkhel* (a ball game of the Bihu season).
- ☐ **Indian board games**: chaturanga, pachisi/chaupar, Moksha Patam, aadu puli attam, pallanguzhi (Part 4).

SPT-18 Traditional games of the world

Before you start — SPT-18. Every country has its folk games; UNESCO's Intangible Cultural Heritage lists include several.
See also: INS (instruments of the same festivals).

☐ **SPT-18.1 Ball and stick games**: the **Mesoamerican ballgame** (*ulama* survives in Mexico); **cuju** (China); **kemari** (Japan); **calcio storico** (Florence, a rough 16th-century football); **hurling** and **Gaelic football** (Ireland); **pelota** (Basque), **chinlone** (Myanmar, cane ball).

☐ **SPT-18.2 Wrestling traditions**: **sumo** (Japan), **Kırkpınar oil wrestling** (Turkey, by tradition since 1346), **schwingen** (Switzerland), **glíma** (Iceland), **ssireum** (Korea), Senegalese *laamb*, Mongolian *bökh*.

☐ **SPT-18.3 Festivals of games**: **Naadam** (Mongolia: wrestling, horse racing and archery), the **Highland Games** (Scotland: caber toss, hammer), the **Nomad Games** (Central Asia), **Kila Raipur** (India).

☐ **SPT-18.4 Horse and animal games**: **buzkashi** (Afghanistan, Central Asia), **chovgan** (Azerbaijani polo), camel racing (Gulf), **pato** (Argentina's national game).

☐ **SPT-18.5 Throwing and target games**: **pétanque** and **boules** (France), **bocce** (Italy), **kubb** (Sweden), **jianzi** (Chinese shuttlecock kicking), **sepak takraw** (South-East Asia).

☐ **SPT-18.6 Children's games everywhere**: hopscotch, marbles, tops, cat's cradle, skipping rope, tag, hide-and-seek: the same games turn up in every continent, a sign of shared human play.

PART 7 — PARASPORTS AND INCLUSIVE GAMES

SPT-19 Parasports and inclusive games

Before you start — SPT-19. Parasports began in rehabilitation hospitals after the Second World War. Today the **Paralympics** are the second-largest multi-sport event. **Classification** groups athletes by how their impairment affects their sport, so competition is fair.

☐ **SPT-19.1 Origins**: **Ludwig Guttmann**'s Stoke Mandeville Games for wounded veterans (England, 1948); the first **Paralympic Games** (Rome, 1960); the **International Paralympic Committee** (1989).

☐ **SPT-19.2 Paralympic sports**: para athletics, para swimming, wheelchair basketball, wheelchair rugby, wheelchair tennis, para badminton, para archery, para shooting, sitting volleyball, boccia, **goalball** (for blind athletes, with a ball that has bells), blind football, para powerlifting, para canoe, para cycling, wheelchair fencing.

☐ **SPT-19.3 Other movements**: the **Deaflympics** (Paris, 1924), the **Special Olympics** (for people with intellectual disabilities; founded by Eunice Kennedy Shriver, 1968), the **Invictus Games** (for wounded service members, 2014), the World Dwarf Games.

☐ **SPT-19.4 Blind cricket and other adapted games**: blind cricket (a ball with ball-bearings that rattle; World Cups since 1998; India won the T20 World Cups of 2012, 2017 and 2022), wheelchair cricket, deaf cricket, adaptive chess (tactile boards).

☐ **SPT-19.5 India's Paralympians**: **Murlikant Petkar** (India's first Paralympic gold, swimming, 1972), **Devendra Jhajharia** (javelin gold 2004 and 2016), **Avani Lekhara** (shooting gold 2020 and 2024), **Sumit Antil** (javelin gold 2020 and 2024), **Sheetal Devi** (archer without arms, Paralympic bronze 2024), Pramod Bhagat, Mariyappan Thangavelu; India won 29 medals (7 gold) at Paris 2024, its best ever.

☐ **SPT-19.6 Inclusive play**: unified sports (players with and without disabilities together), accessible playgrounds, adapted PE in schools, the language of respect ("athlete with a disability", not "victim").

PART 8 — HISTORY AND EVOLUTION

About this Part. From ancient festivals to the TV age and esports, as a year-wise register and as the big stories. **See also:** MOV (sports films), BOK (sports books).

SPT-20 The Sports Timeline (year-wise register)

Year	Event	Where	Why it matters
c. 3100 BCE	Senet boards in Egyptian tombs	Egypt	Among the oldest board games
c. 2600 BCE	Royal Game of Ur	Mesopotamia	Oldest playable rules (reconstructed)
c. 1650 BCE	Rubber balls of the Mesoamerican ballgame	Mexico	The first bouncing balls
776 BCE	First recorded Olympic Games (by tradition)	Olympia, Greece	Start of the Olympic story
c. 3rd century BCE	Cuju football in China (Han era onward)	China	Earliest documented football
c. 6th century CE	Chaturanga	India	Ancestor of chess
393 CE	Last ancient Olympics (traditional date)	Olympia	Pagan festivals banned
1346	Kırkpınar oil wrestling (by tradition)	Ottoman Thrace	Among the oldest continuous competitions
1744	First known Laws of Cricket	London	Cricket's written rules
1787	Marylebone Cricket Club (MCC) founded	London	Keeper of the Laws (1788)
1829	First Oxford–Cambridge Boat Race	London	Early varsity sport
1851	America's Cup	Isle of Wight	Oldest international trophy
1862	Calcutta Polo Club	Kolkata	Modern polo, learned from Manipur
1863	Football Association rules	London	Birth of association football
1870s	Badminton played in Poona	Pune	A world sport born in India
1875	Snooker devised	Jabalpur	Another game born in India
1877	First Wimbledon; first Test match (Melbourne)	London; Melbourne	Tennis and Test cricket begin
1886	World Chess Championship (Steinitz)	USA	First official world champion
1891	Basketball invented (Naismith)	Springfield, USA	A sport designed from scratch
1894	IOC founded by Pierre de Coubertin	Paris	Olympic revival
1896	First modern Olympics	Athens	241 athletes, 14 nations
1900	Women at the Olympics; Norman Pritchard's medals for India	Paris	Women and India enter
1903	First Tour de France	France	Cycling's greatest race
1904	FIFA founded	Paris	World football body
1924	First Winter Olympics; FIDE founded	Chamonix; Paris	Winter sport and world chess
1928	India's first Olympic hockey gold (Dhyan Chand)	Amsterdam	The golden era of Indian hockey begins
1930	First FIFA World Cup (Uruguay); first British Empire Games	Montevideo; Hamilton, Canada	World Cup and Commonwealth Games begin
1948	Stoke Mandeville Games	England	Birth of parasport
1951	First Asian Games	New Delhi	Asia's Olympics, born in India
1952	K. D. Jadhav's wrestling bronze	Helsinki	Independent India's first individual Olympic medal
1960	First Paralympic Games	Rome	Parasport goes global

1972	First video-game tournament	Stanford, USA	Birth of esports
1973	First Women's Cricket World Cup (before the men's)	England	Women's cricket leads
1975	First men's Cricket World Cup (West Indies)	England	Limited-overs cricket goes global
1983	India wins the Cricket World Cup (Kapil Dev)	Lord's, London	Changes Indian sport forever
1988	Ben Johnson stripped of Olympic gold	Seoul	Doping scandal leads toward WADA
1991	First FIFA Women's World Cup (USA)	China	Women's football on the world stage
1999	World Anti-Doping Agency (WADA) founded	Lausanne	Global anti-doping rules
2000	Karnam Malleswari's bronze; Anand world champion	Sydney; Tehran–New Delhi	Firsts for Indian women and Indian chess
2007	First T20 World Cup (India)	South Africa	T20 boom
2008	IPL founded; Abhinav Bindra's gold	India; Beijing	Franchise cricket; India's first individual Olympic gold
2016	AlphaGo beats Lee Sedol	Seoul	AI masters Go
2021	Neeraj Chopra's javelin gold (Tokyo 2020 Games)	Tokyo	First Indian Olympic gold in athletics
2022	Esports medal events at the Asian Games	Hangzhou (held 2023)	Esports enter a multi-sport games
2024	Gukesh world chess champion; India's double Olympiad gold	Singapore; Budapest	Indian chess at the top
2025	India's women win the ODI World Cup; first Kho Kho World Cup	India	New firsts for Indian sport
2026	Spain win the 48-team FIFA World Cup; India win the T20 World Cup; Milano Cortina Winter Olympics	USA, Canada, Mexico; India and Sri Lanka; Italy	Latest landmarks (checked 3 November 2026)
2028	Los Angeles Olympics with cricket, squash, lacrosse and flag football	USA	Cricket returns after 128 years
2030	Centenary Commonwealth Games	Ahmedabad, India	India hosts the CWG again

SPT-21 The big stories of sport

☐ **SPT-21.1 Codification**: why 19th-century Britain wrote rules for so many games (railways, public schools, clubs, newspapers, the Empire); India's part in badminton, snooker and polo.

☐ **SPT-21.2 The amateur ideal and its end**: the Olympics banned professionals for decades (Jim Thorpe was stripped of his medals in 1913, restored in 1982); professionals were fully admitted from the 1980s–90s.

☐ **SPT-21.3 Sport and empire**: cricket in India and the Caribbean; C. L. R. James and Ashis Nandy on cricket as both colonial and anti-colonial (SPT-28); Mohun Bagan's barefoot win over the East Yorkshire Regiment in the 1911 IFA Shield.

☐ **SPT-21.4 Broadcasting and money**: radio (AIR cricket commentary from the 1930s–40s), TV (Doordarshan's 1982 Asian Games in colour), satellite TV and Kerry Packer's World Series Cricket (1977), streaming rights worth billions.

☐ **SPT-21.5 The rise of women's sport**: from the first women at the 1900 Olympics to equal numbers of men and women at Paris 2024 (the first "gender-equal" Games by athlete quota); Billie Jean King's "Battle of the Sexes" (1973); equal prize money at the Grand Slams; women's leagues (WPL, WSL); the Indian women's cricket World Cup of 2025.

☐ **SPT-21.6 Boycotts and politics**: the apartheid sports boycott of South Africa (1960s–1991), the Moscow 1980 and Los Angeles 1984 boycotts, the Munich massacre (1972), the Black Power salute (Mexico City, 1968).

☐ **SPT-21.7 Esports and the digital age**: SPT-16.

PART 9 — EVENTS AND COMPETITIONS

About this Part. The great multi-sport games, world championships and leagues, with first edition, first winner, most titles and the latest winner. Latest results were checked on 3 November 2026.

SPT-22 Multi-sport games

☐ **SPT-22.1 Summer Olympic Games**: every four years since 1896; Paris 2024 (USA top of the table; India won six medals: one silver and five bronze); next Los Angeles 2028, Brisbane 2032. India has announced its bid for 2036.

☐ **SPT-22.2 Winter Olympic Games**: since 1924; Milano Cortina 2026 (Norway top); next French Alps 2030.

☐ **SPT-22.3 Paralympic Games**: since 1960 (Summer) and 1976 (Winter); Paris 2024 (China top; India 29 medals).

☐ **SPT-22.4 Youth Olympic Games** (2010), **World Games** (non-Olympic sports, 1981), **Universiade / World University Games**.

☐ **SPT-22.5 Asian Games**: since 1951 (New Delhi); the 2026 Games at Aichi–Nagoya, Japan (19 September–4 October 2026): China top, India 85 medals.

☐ **SPT-22.6 Commonwealth Games**: since 1930 (Hamilton, Canada); Glasgow 2026 (23 July–2 August, a smaller programme): India fourth with 39 medals (13 gold, 17 silver, 9 bronze); the centenary Games go to **Ahmedabad in 2030**.

☐ **SPT-22.7 Other regional games**: South Asian Games, Pan American Games, African Games, European Games, Pacific Games, Mediterranean Games, Arab Games.

☐ **SPT-22.8 India's national events**: the National Games (since 1924 as the Indian Olympic Games), **Khelo India** Youth, University, Para and Winter Games (since 2018), Santosh Trophy (football, 1941), Ranji Trophy (cricket, 1934), Durand Cup (football, 1888, one of the oldest football tournaments in the world).

SPT-23 World championships and leagues register

Before you start — SPT-23. "Most titles" counts the main men's or open competition unless stated. Latest winners checked 3 November 2026; the website updates each row after every edition.

Event	First edition · first winner	Most titles	Latest winner (checked 3 Nov 2026)	Governing body	Note
FIFA World Cup (men)	1930 · Uruguay	Brazil (5)	2026 · Spain	FIFA	First 48-team edition, USA/Canada/Mexico
FIFA Women's World Cup	1991 · USA	USA (4)	2023 · Spain	FIFA	Next 2027, Brazil
Cricket World Cup (ODI, men)	1975 · West Indies	Australia (6)	2023 · Australia	ICC	Next 2027, Southern Africa
Women's Cricket World Cup (ODI)	1973 · England	Australia (7)	2025 · India	ICC	India's first title
T20 World Cup (men)	2007 · India	India (3)	2026 · India	ICC	Beat New Zealand by 96 runs in the final
Indian Premier League	2008 · Rajasthan Royals	Mumbai Indians, Chennai Super Kings (5 each)	2026 · Royal Challengers Bengaluru	BCCI	RCB's second title in a row
Hockey World Cup (men)	1971 · Pakistan	Pakistan (4)	2026 · Germany	FIH	Germany beat Spain 1–0 in the final
Rugby World Cup (men)	1987 · New Zealand	South Africa (4)	2023 · South Africa	World Rugby	Next 2027, Australia
Wimbledon (singles)	1877 · Spencer Gore	Roger Federer, Martina Navratilova	2026 · Jannik Sinner and Linda Nosková	AELTC	Grand Slam on grass
Tour de France	1903 · Maurice Garin	Several riders with 5	2026 · Tadej Pogačar	ASO, UCI	Three-week stage race
Formula One World Championship	1950 · Giuseppe Farina	Schumacher, Hamilton (7 each)	2025 · Lando Norris	FIA	2026 season in progress at time of checking
World Chess Championship	1886 · Wilhelm Steinitz	Emanuel Lasker (27 years as champion)	D. Gukesh (since 2024)	FIDE	2026 challenger: Javokhir Sindarov

Kho Kho World Cup	2025 · India (men and women)	India	2025 · India	International Kho Kho Federation	First edition, New Delhi
Ballon d'Or (men)	1956 · Stanley Matthews	Lionel Messi (8)	2026 · Harry Kane	France Football, UEFA	Women's award since 2018

PART 10 — AWARDS AND HONOURS

SPT-24 International awards

☐ **SPT-24.1 Laureus World Sports Awards** (since 2000): the "Oscars of sport". In April 2026 (Madrid) **Carlos Alcaraz** and **Aryna Sabalenka** were Sportsman and Sportswoman of the Year, and **Paris Saint-Germain** Team of the Year. Sachin Tendulkar's 2011 World Cup lap of honour won the Laureus Sporting Moment (2000–2020) award.

☐ **SPT-24.2 Football**: the **Ballon d'Or** (France Football, 1956; women's since 2018, first winner Ada Hegerberg; 2025 winners Ousmane Dembélé and Aitana Bonmatí; 2026 men's winner Harry Kane), **The Best FIFA Football Awards** (2016), the Golden Boot.

☐ **SPT-24.3 Cricket**: **ICC Awards** (since 2004; the Sir Garfield Sobers Trophy and the Rachael Heyhoe Flint Award), **Wisden Cricketers of the Year** (since 1889), ICC Hall of Fame.

☐ **SPT-24.4 Chess**: FIDE titles (Grandmaster since 1950; International Master; Woman Grandmaster), the Chess Oscar.

☐ **SPT-24.5 Other awards**: BBC Sports Personality of the Year (1954), *Sports Illustrated* Sportsperson of the Year (1954), World Athletics Athlete of the Year, BWF Player of the Year, the Olympic Order, the Pierre de Coubertin Medal (sportsmanship).

☐ **SPT-24.6 Halls of Fame**: the ICC, FIBA, International Tennis, World Rugby and many national halls.

SPT-25 India's sports awards

Before you start — SPT-25. India's National Sports Awards are given by the Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports, traditionally around 29 August, National Sports Day (Major Dhyan Chand's birthday).

☐ **SPT-25.1 Major Dhyan Chand Khel Ratna** (since 1991–92; renamed in 2021 from the Rajiv Gandhi Khel Ratna): India's highest sports honour. The first winner was **Viswanathan Anand**. The awards for 2024 (presented January 2025) went to D. Gukesh, Manu Bhaker, Harmanpreet Singh and Praveen Kumar. For **2025**, announced in August 2026, **no Khel Ratna was given**.

☐ **SPT-25.2 Arjuna Award** (since 1961): for outstanding performance; the 2025 list (announced August 2026) includes, as reported, Tejaswin Shankar, and the badminton pair Treesa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand; the full list is on yas.gov.in.

☐ **SPT-25.3 Dronacharya Award** (since 1985): for coaches; the **Dhyan Chand Award for Lifetime Achievement** (2002), the **Rashtriya Khel Protsahan Puraskar** (for organisations), the **Maulana Abul Kalam Azad (MAKA) Trophy** (for universities).

☐ **SPT-25.4 Padma awards and the Bharat Ratna**: **Sachin Tendulkar** became the first sportsperson to receive the Bharat Ratna (2014); many athletes have received Padma awards (Milkha Singh, Mary Kom, P. V. Sindhu, Neeraj Chopra and others).

☐ **SPT-25.5 State awards**: Shiv Chhatrapati (Maharashtra), Eklavya (Karnataka and others), Maharana Pratap (Rajasthan) and more.

PART 11 — PEOPLE OF SPORT

SPT-26 Legends, coaches and record-holders

Before you start — SPT-26. A starting list, by sport; every name gets a profile with dates, records and honours on the website.

☐ **SPT-26.1 Cricket**: W. G. Grace, Don Bradman (Test average 99.94), Garfield Sobers, Viv Richards, Imran Khan, Kapil Dev, Sunil Gavaskar, Sachin Tendulkar (100 international hundreds), Muttiah Muralitharan, Shane Warne, M. S. Dhoni, Virat Kohli, Rohit Sharma, Jasprit Bumrah; women: Rachael Heyhoe Flint, Mithali Raj, Jhulan Goswami, Ellyse Perry, Harmanpreet Kaur, Smriti Mandhana.

☐ **SPT-26.2 Football**: Pelé, Diego Maradona, Johan Cruyff, Zinedine Zidane, Lionel Messi, Cristiano Ronaldo, Marta, Megan Rapinoe, Aitana Bonmatí; India: Sailen Manna, P. K. Banerjee, Chuni Goswami, I. M. Vijayan, Bhaichung Bhutia, **Sunil Chhetri** (among the top international goal-scorers of all time).

☐ **SPT-26.3 Hockey**: **Major Dhyan Chand** (three Olympic golds, 1928, 1932, 1936), Balbir Singh Sr. (five goals in the 1952 Olympic final), Dhanraj Pillay, P. R. Sreejesh, Harmanpreet Singh, Rani Rampal.

☐ **SPT-26.4 Athletics and swimming**: Jesse Owens (four golds, Berlin 1936), Carl Lewis, Usain Bolt, Paavo Nurmi, Abebe Bikila (barefoot marathon gold, 1960), Fanny Blankers-Koen, Florence Griffith-Joyner, Eliud Kipchoge, Michael Phelps, Katie Ledecky; India: Milkha Singh, P. T. Usha, Neeraj Chopra.

☐ **SPT-26.5 Racket sports**: Rod Laver, Billie Jean King, Martina Navratilova, Steffi Graf, Serena Williams, Roger Federer, Rafael Nadal, Novak Djokovic (24 Grand Slam singles titles), Carlos Alcaraz, Jannik Sinner; Lin Dan, Prakash Padukone, P. V. Sindhu; Ma Long.

☐ **SPT-26.6 Chess**: José Raúl Capablanca, Bobby Fischer, Garry Kasparov, Magnus Carlsen, Judit Polgár, Viswanathan Anand, Koneru Humpy, D. Gukesh, R. Praggnanandhaa, Divya Deshmukh.

☐ **SPT-26.7 Combat and strength**: Muhammad Ali, Mary Kom, Great Gama, K. D. Jadhav, Sakshi Malik, Vinesh Phogat, Karnam Malleswari, Mirabai Chanu.

☐ **SPT-26.8 Others**: Pelé of basketball Michael Jordan, Nadia Comăneci, Simone Biles, Ayrton Senna, Lewis Hamilton, Tiger Woods, Abhinav Bindra, Pankaj Advani, Mihir Sen, Tenzing Norgay, Shiva Keshavan.

☐ **SPT-26.9 Great coaches**: Sir Alex Ferguson, Pep Guardiola, Rinus Michels, Phil Jackson, Ramakant Achrekar (Tendulkar's coach), Syed Abdul Rahim (India's football coach, 1950s–60s Asian Games golds), O. M. Nambiar (P. T. Usha), Pullela Gopichand (Sindhu, Saina), Mahavir Singh Phogat, Gurcharan Singh Gogi; Indian coaching in the Dronacharya list.

PART 12 — THE SCIENCE OF SPORT

SPT-27 Sports science, medicine, doping and technology

Before you start — SPT-27. Modern sport is a laboratory: of the body, of fairness and of technology. **See also:** TEC (sensors, cameras, AI), COK (nutrition).

☐ **SPT-27.1 Exercise physiology**: aerobic and anaerobic energy; VO_2 max; altitude training (Kenyan and Ethiopian runners, Iten and the Rift Valley); heat and hydration.

☐ **SPT-27.2 Biomechanics**: the physics of the javelin throw, the fast-bowling action, the high-jump flop, the golf swing; motion-capture and force plates.

☐ **SPT-27.3 Sports nutrition**: carbohydrates for endurance, protein for repair, iron and vitamin D; Indian vegetarian athletes; supplements can be contaminated, so athletes must check (SPT-27.6).

☐ **SPT-27.4 Sports medicine and injuries**: ACL tears (more common in women footballers), concussion protocols (cricket's concussion substitute since 2019), overuse in young athletes, return-to-play rules; physiotherapists and sports doctors.

☐ **SPT-27.5 Sports psychology**: goal setting, visualisation, pre-performance routines, pressure and "choking", flow (SPT-28.2), mental health (Naomi Osaka, Simone Biles, Ben Stokes spoke openly).

☐ **SPT-27.6 Doping and anti-doping**: the **World Anti-Doping Agency** (WADA, 1999) and the World Anti-Doping Code; India's **NADA** (2005); the Ben Johnson (1988) and Lance Armstrong (stripped of seven Tour titles, 2012) cases; state-sponsored doping in Russia (the McLaren Report, 2016); "strict liability": athletes are responsible for what is in their bodies.

☐ **SPT-27.7 Fairness debates**: sex testing and eligibility rules; the Dutee Chand case at the Court of Arbitration for Sport (2015); transgender participation policies set by each federation; classification in parasport (SPT-19).

☐ **SPT-27.8 Officiating technology**: **Hawk-Eye** ball-tracking (tennis from 2006, cricket DRS from 2008–09), **goal-line technology** (FIFA World Cup 2014), **VAR** (World Cup 2018), semi-automated offside (2022), UltraEdge and snickometer, TMO in rugby, photo finish and electronic timing.

☐ **SPT-27.9 Equipment technology**: carbon-plated running shoes, the full-body swimsuits banned in 2010, aluminium bats (banned in cricket after Dennis Lillee, 1979), smart balls, wearables and GPS vests; data analytics ("Moneyball").

PART 13 — IDEAS: PLAY, PHILOSOPHY, PSYCHOLOGY AND SOCIETY

SPT-28 Why we play, and what sport does to us

Before you start — SPT-28. Philosophers, psychologists and historians have asked what play is, why competition grips us and what sport does to nations. **See also:** BOK-20 (ideas), MUS-22 (music and the mind).

☐ SPT-28.1 Theories of play

☐ **Johan Huizinga**, *Homo Ludens* (1938): play is older than culture and lies at its root; play happens in a "magic circle" with its own rules.

☐ **Roger Caillois**, *Man, Play and Games* (1958): four kinds of play: *agôn* (competition), *alea* (chance), *mimicry* (role-play) and *ilinx* (vertigo, such as swings and roller-coasters).

☐ **Bernard Suits**, *The Grasshopper* (1978): a game is "the voluntary attempt to overcome unnecessary obstacles" (SPT-00.05).

☐ **Indian ideas**: *lila* (divine play, the world as Krishna's play); *krida* in Sanskrit texts; the *Mahabharata*'s dice game as a lesson on chance and dharma.

☐ SPT-28.2 The psychology of competition

☐ **Flow** (Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi, 1990): total absorption when challenge matches skill.

☐ **Motivation**: intrinsic (joy) and extrinsic (medals, money); why young athletes quit when sport stops being fun.

☐ **Home advantage**, **the "hot hand"** (once called a myth, now debated with new data), **choking under pressure**.

☐ SPT-28.3 Sport and society

☐ **Fandom** (SPT-00.06): belonging, identity and rivalry.

☐ **Nationalism**: George Orwell called international sport "war minus the shooting" ("The Sporting Spirit", 1945); sport can also build peace (Ping-Pong Diplomacy, the 2018 joint Korean team).

☐ **Cricket and India**: **C. L. R. James**, *Beyond a Boundary* (1963): "What do they know of cricket who only cricket know?"; **Ashis Nandy**, *The Tao of Cricket* (1989): "Cricket is an Indian game accidentally discovered by the English"; **Ramachandra Guha**, *A Corner of a Foreign Field* (2002) on caste and the Palwankar brothers.

☐ **Gender**: unequal pay and coverage; the women who changed sport; the safety of women athletes; India's women in cricket, wrestling, boxing, badminton and shooting.

☐ **Caste, class and access**: who gets to play; Palwankar Baloo (a Dalit spin bowler of the early 1900s); grassroots academies and scholarship schemes.

☐ **Money and ethics**: match-fixing (the 2000 cricket scandal, the 2013 IPL spot-fixing case), betting, player power, sportswashing by states.

☐ **Gaming and the brain**: action video games can improve some visual attention skills (Daphne Bavelier and colleagues); heavy use can harm sleep and study; WHO's gaming disorder (SPT-16.4).

PART 14 — THE PRACTICAL GUIDE

SPT-29 Playing, watching and gaming well

Before you start — SPT-29. For readers of every age who want to start a sport, understand the rules, watch well, run a games night or game healthily. Dates and websites carry a "checked on" date on the site.

☐ **SPT-29.1 How much activity**: the WHO recommends at least 150–300 minutes of moderate (or 75–150 of vigorous) activity a week for adults, plus muscle-strengthening twice a week; children and teenagers an average of 60 minutes a day.

☐ **SPT-29.2 Starting a sport at any age**: start with what you enjoy; join a club or group; learn basic skills from a coach; build up slowly (the "10 per cent a week" rule for runners); older adults can start walking, swimming, yoga, table tennis, badminton, pickleball.

☐ **SPT-29.3 Rules in plain words**: one-page explainers for cricket (lbw, DRS, the follow-on), football (offside), tennis (scoring "love", deuce), kabaddi (raid, bonus line), chess (castling, en passant).

☐ **SPT-29.4 Safety**: warm up and cool down; helmets and guards; heat and hydration in Indian summers; concussion: "if in doubt, sit them out"; safeguarding of children in sport.

☐ **SPT-29.5 Where to watch and follow**: official broadcasters and apps (dated), free-to-air rules for major events in India (Prasar Bharati), official federation sites, radio commentary; avoid pirated streams.

☐ **SPT-29.6 Board-game and quiz nights**: pick games by group size and time; teach in five minutes; include older and younger players; Indian classics (carrom, Ludo, chaupar, antakshari).

☐ **SPT-29.7 Healthy gaming**: time limits, breaks every hour, no screens before sleep, parental controls, beware loot boxes and real-money games (illegal online in India since 2025), play with friends you know.

☐ **SPT-29.8 Careers in sport**: athlete, coach, physio, analyst, referee, sports journalist, sports management, esports; the Sports Authority of India (SAI) schemes and Khelo India scholarships.

PART 15 — REVIEWS AND VOICES

About this Part. Reviews in two forms, as the brief asks: what commentators and writers said (summarised in our own words, with credit) and Kritikesh's own reviews of matches, games and books.

SPT-30 Critics' Corner: great commentators and sports writers

☐ **SPT-30.1 Commentators**: John Arlott, Richie Benaud, Tony Cozier, Harsha Bhogle, Ravi Shastri, Sunil Gavaskar; India's radio pioneers Melville de Mellow, Jasdev Singh (Hindi), Sushil Doshi (Hindi cricket), Anant Setalvad; football's John Motson, Martin Tyler; tennis's Bud Collins; Hindi cricket TV commentary's rise in the 2010s.

☐ **SPT-30.2 Writers**: Neville Cardus, C. L. R. James, Hugh McIlvanney, Red Smith, Grantland Rice, Brian Glanville, Simon Kuper (*Soccernomics*), Nick Hornby (*Fever Pitch*, 1992), Gideon Haigh, Rohit Brijnath, Sharda Ugra, Mukul Kesavan (*Men in White*, 2007), Ramachandra Guha, Boria Majumdar, Novy Kapadia (*Barefoot to Boots*, 2017), Ayaz Memon.

☐ **SPT-30.3 Publications**: *Wisden Cricketers' Almanack* (1864), *Sportstar* (1978), ESPNcricinfo (1993), *The Athletic*, *L'Équipe*, *Sports Illustrated*, *The Cricket Monthly*, *Sportskeeda*, *The Bridge* (Indian Olympic sports).

SPT-31 The critics said, I say (page template)

1. **The match, game or book in two lines**: what, who, when, where, result (spoilers marked for book and film entries).
2. **What the experts said**: 3 to 5 named views, each summarised in one or two lines in my own words, with links and dates.
3. **Where they agree and disagree**.
4. **What I say**: my own view (link to SPT-32).
5. **If you liked this, try next**: three linked matches, players, games or books.

SPT-32 My Review Desk (Kritikesh's match- and game-review template)

☐ **Header**: event or game, sport, date, venue or platform, teams or players, result (dated).

☐ **My one-line verdict**.

☐ **The story of the contest**: key moments and turning points.

☐ **Skill and tactics**: what the best players did differently.

☐ **Spirit**: sportsmanship, crowd, controversy.

☐ **For board and video games**: rules clarity, depth, replay value, fairness, age suitability, price and screen-time honesty.

☐ **Best moment**: a timestamp or a move.

☐ **Who should watch or play it**.

☐ **My rating** on a clear five-point scale, and **tags and try-next links**.

PART 16 — NAVIGATION: TAGS, LINKS AND THE SITE MAP

SPT-33 Tag dictionary

☐ **Branch**: #outdoor #indoor #mindgame #digital #folk #parasport.

☐ **Family**: #teamball #batandball #racket #athletics #water #winter #motor #air #adventure #equestrian #target #gymnastics #strength #combat #martialarts #cue #boardgame #cards #puzzle #quiz #esports.

☐ **Sport**: one tag per sport (#cricket #football #hockey #kabaddi #khokho #badminton #chess #tennis #wrestling #shooting).

☐ **Region**: #india and each state, #asia #europe #africa #americas #oceania, and each country.

☐ **Event**: #olympics #paralympics #asiangames #commonwealthgames #worldcup #ipl #kheloindia.

☐ **Award**: #khelratna #arjuna #dronacharya #laureus #ballondor #iccawards.

☐ **Person**: one tag per profiled player or coach.

☐ **Era**: #ancient #medieval #19thcentury #1900s to #2020s.

☐ **Theme**: #women #inclusion #science #doping #technology #philosophy #fandom #health.

☐ **Level**: #beginner #fan #player #coach.

SPT-34 Cross-links and the website site map

☐ **SPT-34.1 Cross-topic links**: Movies (sports films: MOV); Books (sports writing: BOK); Music (anthems, stadium songs: MUS); Technology (sports tech, gaming, AI: TEC); Cooking (sports nutrition: COK); the Curriculum Index (physical education; games in history) and the Exam Guide (RPSC/RSSB sports current affairs, awards and trophies).

☐ **SPT-34.2 Suggested web addresses**: /sports/ (home, Gateway), /sports/why-we-play/<leaf>/ , /sports/outdoor/<family>/<sport>/ , /sports/indoor/<family>/<sport>/ , /sports/mind-games/<game>/ , /sports/digital/<genre-or-title>/ , /sports/folk/india/<state>/ , /sports/folk/world/<country>/ , /sports/para/<sport>/ , /sports/history/<era>/ , /sports/events/<event>/<year>/ , /sports/awards/<award>/<year>/ , /sports/people/<name>/ , /sports/science/<topic>/ , /sports/ideas/<topic>/ , /sports/guide/<topic>/ , /sports/reviews/<item>/ .

☐ **SPT-34.3 Search phrases to own**: "types of sports list", "traditional games of India", "how chess started in India", "who won the FIFA World Cup 2026", "T20 World Cup 2026 winner", "Khel Ratna award list", "Asian Games 2026 India medals", "rules of kabaddi", "is esports a sport", "best board games for family", with Hindi lines ("bharat ke paramparik khel", "kabaddi ke niyam", "khel ratna puraskar 2025 kise mila").

PART 17 — SOURCES, CREDITS AND EDITOR'S NOTES

SPT-S Sources and credits

Knowledge belongs to the people who made it. These are the sources this index stands on; every page on the website will cite its own.

☐ **Governing bodies**: International Olympic Committee (olympics.com); International Paralympic Committee; FIFA, ICC, FIH, World Rugby, FIBA, FIVB, ITF, BWF, ITTF, World Athletics, World Aquatics, FIDE, FIA, World Archery, ISSF, UWW, and the federations named in each entry; Olympic Council of Asia; Commonwealth Sport.

☐ **India**: Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports (yas.gov.in); Sports Authority of India; Khelo India; Indian Olympic Association; NADA; the National Sports Awards notices.

☐ **Reference and history**: Encyclopaedia Britannica; *Wisden*; David Goldblatt, *The Ball Is Round* (2006) and *The Games* (2016); Ramachandra Guha, *A Corner of a Foreign Field* (2002); Boria Majumdar and others on Indian sport; Irving Finkel on the Royal Game of Ur (British Museum); H. J. R. Murray, *A History of Chess* (1913).

☐ **Ideas and science**: Johan Huizinga, *Homo Ludens* (1938); Roger Caillois (1958); Bernard Suits (1978); Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi, *Flow* (1990); Cialdini and colleagues (1976); Wilbert-Lampen and colleagues, *NEJM* (2008); WADA Code; WHO guidelines on physical activity (2020); WHO ICD-11.

☐ **Latest results checked (3 November 2026)**: FIFA (World Cup 2026, Spain); ICC and press reports (T20 World Cup 2026, India; Women's World Cup 2025, India); IPL 2026 reports (RCB); FIH and All India Radio (Hockey World Cup 2026, Germany); Wimbledon reports (Sinner, Nosková); Tour de France reports (Pogačar); Laureus (April 2026); Ballon d'Or reports (October 2026, Harry Kane); chess.com and FIDE (Candidates 2026: Sindarov, Vaishali); olympics.com and press (Milano Cortina 2026, Norway); press reports (Commonwealth Games 2026, India 39 medals; Asian Games 2026, India 85 medals); Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports and press (National Sports Awards 2025, no Khel Ratna).

SPT-E Editor's notes (corrections and decisions on the brief)

1. **"Chinese checkers" is a German game** (1892), renamed in the USA (SPT-14.3).
2. **Snakes and Ladders and Ludo** are credited to their Indian originals (Moksha Patam and pachisi).
3. **Badminton and snooker** are given their Indian birthplaces (Pune and Jabalpur), with the British officers who codified them.
4. **The William Webb Ellis story** (rugby) and the **776 BCE** Olympic start date are marked as tradition.
5. **Indoor and outdoor**: sports played in both settings are listed once, in their usual home, with cross-links.
6. **Animal sports** carry an ethics note rather than a verdict.
7. **"Every sport ever"** cannot fit one booklet: the index gives the master hierarchy, a 30-sport register and a 14-event register, and the website grows a page per sport.
8. **Latest results** were checked on 3 November 2026. The 2026 Women's Ballon d'Or and the 2026 Formula One champion were not confirmed at the time of checking, so they are not stated.
9. **Added beyond the brief**: India's online-gaming law (2025), fairness debates, officiating technology, caste and access, careers in sport, the gender-equal Paris Games, and India's 2030 Commonwealth Games.

SPT-T My Sports and Games Tracker

Use the ☐ boxes across the booklet to tick what you have played, watched or explored. A simple tracker for each Part: Part · Sections · Explored · Date started · Date finished.

Progress tracker

Part	Sections	Explored ☐	Started	Finished
PART 0 — THE INTRODUCTION TWIG: WHY	9			

DO HUMANS INVENT GAMES, AND THEN CARE SO MUCH?				
PART 1 — THE MASTER MAP OF SPORTS AND GAMES	1			
PART 2 — PHYSICAL SPORTS: OUTDOOR	8			
PART 3 — PHYSICAL SPORTS: INDOOR	4			
PART 4 — MIND GAMES	2			
PART 5 — DIGITAL GAMES AND ESPORTS	1			
PART 6 — TRADITIONAL AND FOLK GAMES	2			
PART 7 — PARASPORTS AND INCLUSIVE GAMES	1			
PART 8 — HISTORY AND EVOLUTION	2			
PART 9 — EVENTS AND COMPETITIONS	2			
PART 10 — AWARDS AND HONOURS	2			
PART 11 — PEOPLE OF SPORT	1			
PART 12 — THE SCIENCE OF SPORT	1			
PART 13 — IDEAS: PLAY, PHILOSOPHY, PSYCHOLOGY AND SOCIETY	1			
PART 14 — THE PRACTICAL GUIDE	1			
PART 15 — REVIEWS AND VOICES	3			
PART 16 — NAVIGATION: TAGS, LINKS AND THE SITE MAP	2			
PART 17 — SOURCES, CREDITS AND EDITOR'S NOTES	3			